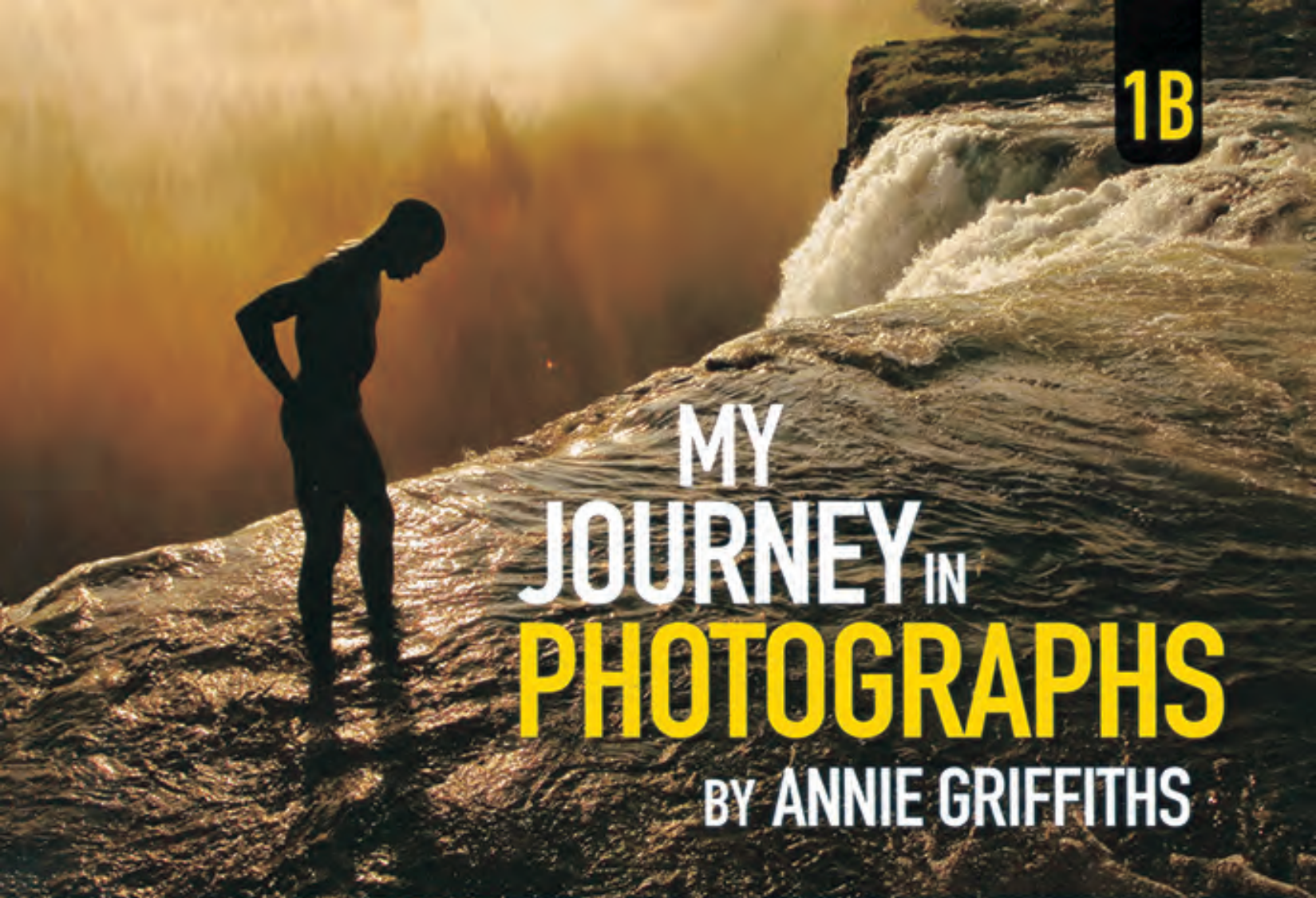




MY JOURNEY IN PHOTOGRAPHS

BY ANNIE GRIFFITHS

Before You Read

A. Matching. You are going to read about award-winning photographer Annie Griffiths. Below are some expressions she uses (1–7) in the reading. Match them to the definitions (a–g) on the left.

1. _____ am knee-deep in
2. _____ by some miracle
3. _____ like a master class
4. _____ of very few words
5. _____ put at ease
6. _____ small talk
7. _____ top-notch

- a. light conversation
- b. make people feel comfortable
- c. excellent training
- d. first-class
- e. have more than enough
- f. incredibly lucky
- g. not speaking very much

B. Discuss. What do you think are the challenges of being a professional photographer? Check your ideas as you read the passage.

^ Annie Griffiths took this photograph of a swimmer standing at the top of a hidden pool, Victoria Falls, South Africa.



Two portraits by >
Annie Griffiths:
(Left) A child peers
between her sisters'
robes in southern
Pakistan (Right) An
old aborigine man
and child

1 **I GOT MY FIRST REAL JOB AT AGE 12**, as a
waitress. I am convinced that I learned more
as a waitress than I ever did in a classroom. It
certainly was more interesting. And when I went
5 on to college, it paid for tuition and housing and,
eventually, a camera. It allowed me to rent an
apartment and feed myself (chicken pot pies,
four for a dollar!). But best of all, being a waitress
taught me to quickly assess and understand all
10 kinds of people. I learned how to make small
talk and how to quickly put people at ease—
great training for a journalist. Waiting tables also
taught me **teamwork** and service and humor.
For the first eight years, I loved it. For the final
15 two years, I just wanted to be a photographer.

From the moment I picked up a camera, I was
hooked. I lost interest in other studies, and all I
wanted to do was take pictures for the university
newspaper, the *Minnesota Daily*. The paper at

20 that time was one of the largest in the state and
was produced by young journalists who went on
to work at every major magazine in the country.
In six months, I was able to get a lot of great
experience. The week I finished college, I was
25 contacted by the *Worthington Daily Globe*, a
regional daily newspaper in southern Minnesota
with a history of excellence in photography. It was
wonderfully printed with fantastic photographs.
By some miracle I was hired, and the two-year
30 experience that followed was like a master class in
photojournalism.

Jim Vance was the top-notch publisher of the
Globe. He had very high **expectations** of all
the **staff**. With little or no instruction from him,
35 writers and photographers were expected to fill
the paper with stories that were important to
our readers. I didn't know it at the time, but this
independent reporting was perfect training for my
future career at *National Geographic*.



40 Among the most important things I learned at
the *Globe* was that if you can make friends with
a shy Norwegian farmer and be invited to his
kitchen table, you can probably do well in any
culture on Earth. I worked with a wonderful
45 writer named Paul Gruchow. Together we would
search the farming communities for stories.
Paul had grown up on a farm himself and lived
through personal tragedy, so he was able to
project warmth and understanding to anyone
50 he met. Farmers would invite us into their homes
and willingly share their personal thoughts with
us. From Paul I learned how to be a patient
listener as well as the importance of giving each
subject time and sincere attention.

55 It was while I was working at the *Globe* that I
happened to answer the phone one morning.
A man's voice asked, "You a photographer?"
When I replied that indeed I was, the voice

60 responded, "This is Bob Gilka. *National
Geographic*. I need a hail¹ damage picture.
You guys get a big hailstorm last night?"
I **overcame** my nervousness and said, "Yes,
sir." When he asked if I could take the picture
for him, I again said, "Yes, sir." **Thus** began
65 one of the most important relationships
of my life, with the legendary Director of
Photography at *National Geographic*,
Bob Gilka.

70 Bob was always looking for talented
photographers to join his team, and he was
not easily impressed. As he used to say, "I am
knee-deep in talent, but only ankle-deep in
ideas. I want people with ideas!" He was a man
of very few words, so every word was heard.
75 **Praise** from Bob meant as much to most
photographers as a Pulitzer Prize.

¹ **Hail** is small balls of ice that fall from the sky like rain.

... if you can make friends with a shy Norwegian farmer and be invited to his kitchen table, you can probably do well in any culture on Earth.

My little picture of hail damage in southern Minnesota was well received, and a year later, I was working for Bob. I was the youngest
80 photographer working for *National Geographic* when I arrived in 1978, and I spent at least a decade just trying not to make mistakes. While I was grateful for the opportunity, it was very difficult for me. With each new assignment came
85 the fear that this was going to be the one where they figured out that I couldn't do the job.

On many assignments, the most challenging part **turned out** to be the transportation. Over the years, I traveled by horse, car, train, truck,
90 and all sorts of old vehicles. I traveled by mule² in Mexico, by ship along the Indian Ocean, by fishing boat in the Sea of Galilee, by moped³ in Bermuda, by sailboat in Sydney. I flew in helicopters chasing bears in the Arctic. Twice,
95 while flying in light planes, pilots have had to make emergency landings far from any airport. But there were also wonderful experiences. In Africa I traveled by balloon, ultralight aircraft, and elephant. In a rubber raft off the west coast of
100 Mexico, I was suddenly lifted out of the water on the back of a friendly whale.

Wherever I traveled in the world, taking beautiful pictures was always my goal. However, later in my career, I also wanted my
105 pictures to make a real difference in people's lives. That is why each spring I tour two or three developing countries, shooting **portraits** of people whose lives are better because of the dedicated workers who care about them. The photos are used in a variety of fund-raising⁴
110 products. The other issue that stole my heart was the environment. With support from the National Geographic Expeditions Council, I have traveled all over the United States to photograph the last one percent of wilderness left here.

I am deeply grateful for my life in photography and the amazing lessons it has taught me. I have learned that women really do hold
120 up half the sky; that language isn't always necessary, but touch usually is; that all people are not alike, but they do mostly have the same hopes and fears; that judging others does great harm, but listening to them **enriches**; and that it is impossible to hate a group of people once
125 you get to know one of them as an individual.

² A **mule** is a hybrid between a horse and a donkey.

³ A **moped** is a type of lightweight motorcycle.

⁴ **Fund-raising** is collecting or earning money for a charity, a school, a political party, etc.

A high-angle photograph of a Bedouin man in traditional white and red attire standing on a large, flat, reddish-brown rock ledge. The ledge has distinct horizontal sedimentary layers. In the background, a vast, deep canyon with layered rock walls stretches towards distant mountains under a clear sky. The lighting suggests late afternoon or early morning, with long shadows and warm tones.

A Bedouin surveys
the view around
Petra, Jordan. ✓

Reading Comprehension

Multiple Choice. Choose the best answer for each question.

Purpose

1. What is the purpose of the first paragraph?
 - a. to describe what life was like working as a waitress
 - b. to explain how waitressing helped prepare Griffiths for life as a photographer
 - c. to compare Griffiths' life before and after becoming a waitress
 - d. to complain about how working as a waitress affected Griffiths' university studies

Vocabulary

2. In lines 16–17, the expression *I was hooked* is closest in meaning to _____.
 - a. I was hurt
 - b. I was employed
 - c. I was addicted
 - d. I was successful

Sequence

3. What happened after Griffiths graduated from college?
 - a. She picked up a camera for the first time.
 - b. She got a job at the *Minnesota Daily*.
 - c. She got a job at the *Worthington Daily Globe*.
 - d. She started taking photos for the university newspaper.

Detail

4. Which sentence does NOT describe Griffiths' job at the *Globe*?
 - a. She received detailed instructions from her publisher.
 - b. She learned to be a patient listener and give people attention.
 - c. The job prepared Griffiths well for a job at *National Geographic*.
 - d. She and the writers were expected to fill the paper with stories that were important to readers.

Detail

5. What first brought Griffiths to the attention of *National Geographic*?
 - a. a photo she had published in the *Globe*
 - b. a photo that *National Geographic* had asked her to take for them
 - c. a photo she secretly sent to *National Geographic*
 - d. a photo of hers sent by a college friend to *National Geographic*

Detail

6. What did Griffiths find especially challenging when on assignments?
 - a. the weather
 - b. wild animals
 - c. the transportation
 - d. being away from home

Detail

7. According to the passage, what has life as a *National Geographic* photographer taught Griffiths?
 - a. that language is important
 - b. that people have different hopes and fears
 - c. that judging people does great harm
 - d. that one can never really know people as individuals

Critical Thinking

Interpreting: Griffiths says she has learned that “women really do hold up half the sky.” What do you think she means by this?

Discussion: What do you think would be Griffiths' advice for someone who wanted to get a job as a professional photographer?

Scanning for Specific Details

When you scan to find specific details, such as dates, names, amounts, or places, you need to have a clear idea of the kind of information you are looking for. If possible, have one or two key words in mind. Then quickly read through the material, looking only for these words or related words. Don't try to read every word and don't worry about understanding everything. When you find the relevant word(s), read the surrounding context to check how the information relates to the rest of the text.

A. Scanning. Use content words (names, places, dates, etc.) in each sentence below to help you quickly locate the section of the reading it relates to. Then mark the sentences **T** (True) or **F** (False). All information is in paragraphs 1–5.

1. ____ The best thing about being a waitress was that it allowed Griffiths to buy a camera.
2. ____ Griffiths worked at the *Worthington Daily Globe* for two years and six months.
3. ____ The *Worthington Daily Globe* was wonderfully printed with fantastic photographs.
4. ____ Jim Vance was the publisher of the *Worthington Daily Globe*.
5. ____ Paul Gruchow was a Norwegian farmer she took photographs of.
6. ____ Griffiths' first photo for *National Geographic* was a picture of hail.

B. Scanning. Use content words (names, places, dates, etc.) in each sentence below to help you quickly locate the section of the reading it relates to. Then complete the sentences. All information is in paragraphs 6–10.

1. Griffiths compares getting praise from Bob Gilka to receiving a _____ Prize.
2. Griffiths got a job with *National Geographic* a _____ after sending them her photo.
3. Griffiths describes traveling by _____ and in a _____ while on assignment in Mexico.
4. Griffiths has had to make _____ emergency landings while flying.
5. Griffiths wants to take photos that make a _____ in people's lives.
6. According to Griffiths, language is not always necessary, but _____ usually is.